But then, Rudolf introduced a caveat into the matter. He would gladly walk into fire and burn – or not – but he would not admit it as a test. They were all three sinners, he said, of himself and his colleagues; how could they presume that God wanted to save them? Besides, when even Christ had refused to trouble God for miracles, how dare the Fathers?

At this, Akbar replied that he hadn't invited the Fathers all this way from Goa just to roast them alive. All he wanted, he said, was to enlist them in tricking a 'religious preceptor' (possibly the Shaikh Qutubuddin of Badauni's story). Rudolf refused, declaring primly that, as priests, they were neither allowed to 'kill a man . . . [nor] make any attempts to bring about a man's execution'.

Akbar insisted: 'I do not wish you to undergo the ordeal; I only desire that you should say you will'.

But no. 'We cannot do even that, O King.'

What if Akbar made the challenge on the Fathers' behalf? They need not implicate themselves in a lie, only remain silent through it. But again, Rudolf refused, declaring he would announce his dissent loudly should Akbar do any such thing.

Thus, it appears, Akbar's fire fizzled out under the wet blanket of the padre's piety; but the stories remain, and they cast a most revealing light upon the emperor. Azfar Moin, who analyses these three narratives of the Fire Test in some detail, suggests that Akbar's alleged enthusiasm for the trial reveals, or underlines, two core facets of the emperor's personality: '[his] fondness for "hands on" knowledge and [for] public spectacle'. Just as he enjoyed the battle of the sanyasis, long ago, on the banks of the lake in Kurukshetra, so, now, he delighted in the equally gladiatorial combat between 'learned men of all stripes . . . [competing] with each other in an arena specially built for this purpose'.[9]

More than one writer has described the emperor's sheer physicality – the punch to Adham Khan's face or the leaping on to musth elephants, of course, but also less dramatic activity. Father Monserrate, for example, describes the emperor joining his workmen to quarry stone for one of his many building projects; or visiting workshops he'd built for various artisans – goldsmiths and gunsmiths, painters and weavers – to relax 'his mind with watching . . . their work'. Later Jesuit priests would describe the emperor as